

1. Why do people believe implausible claims, e.g., conspiracies?



2. Is base gullibility critical to the acceptance of conspiratorial claims^{1,3-5}?

Key Predictions of Gullibility Hypothesis:

- Conspiracy believers are *overconfident*
- Overconfidence should bias perceptions of reality

Current Work

3 Studies: 1,485 participants

Materials

Belief in Conspiracy Theories⁶ (BCTI)

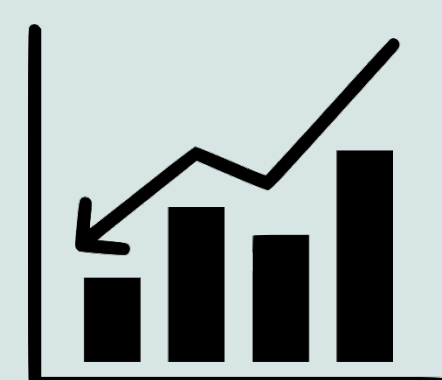
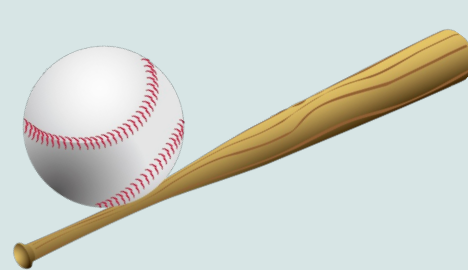
E.g., “The Apollo moon landings never happened and were staged in a Hollywood film studio”



3 Overconfidence measures:

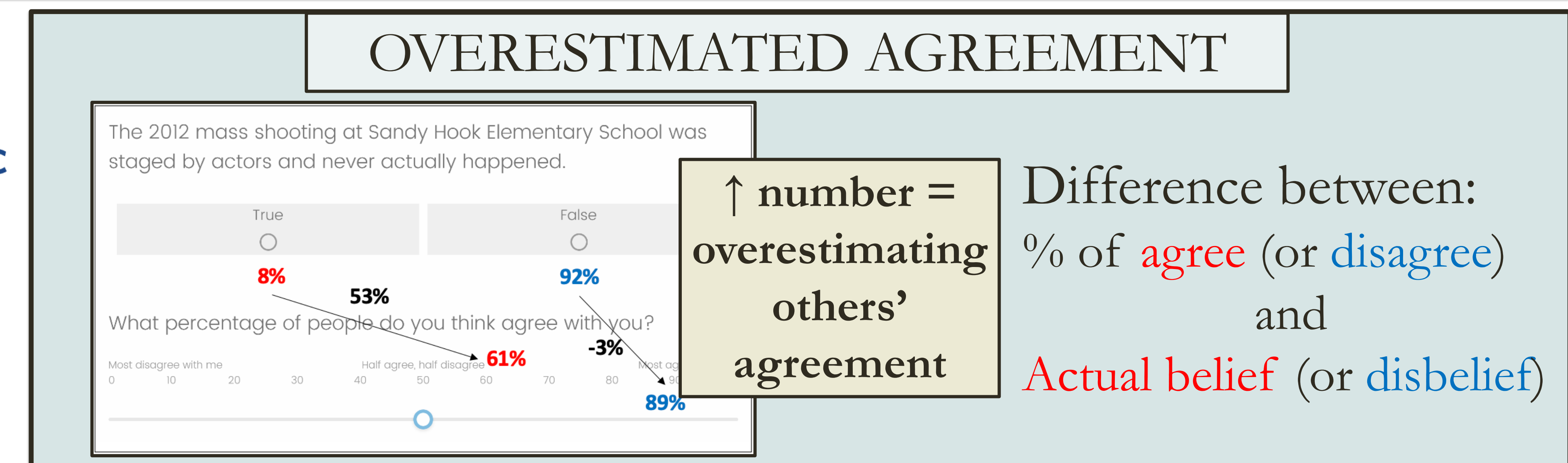
Overconfidence = Estimated – Actual performance

Cognitive Reflection Test⁷, Numeracy^{8,9}, and Perceptual task¹⁰



Conspiracy believers massively overestimate how much others agree with them

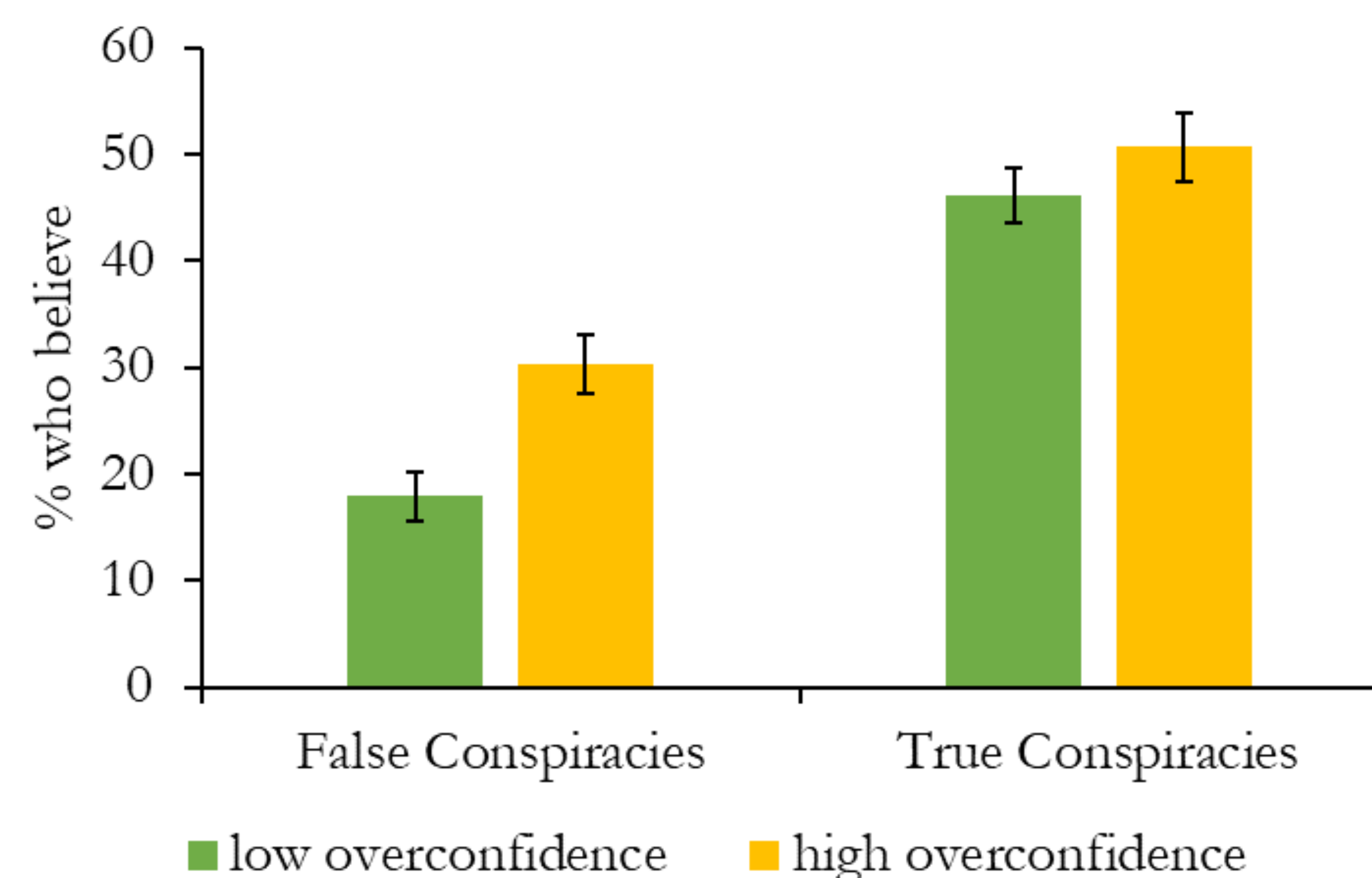
Study	N	Source
1	302	Prolific
2	591	LUCID
3	592	amazon mechanical turk



Conspiracy beliefs

Correlation b/w conspiracy beliefs and accuracy/overconfidence (for Studies 1, 2, 3)

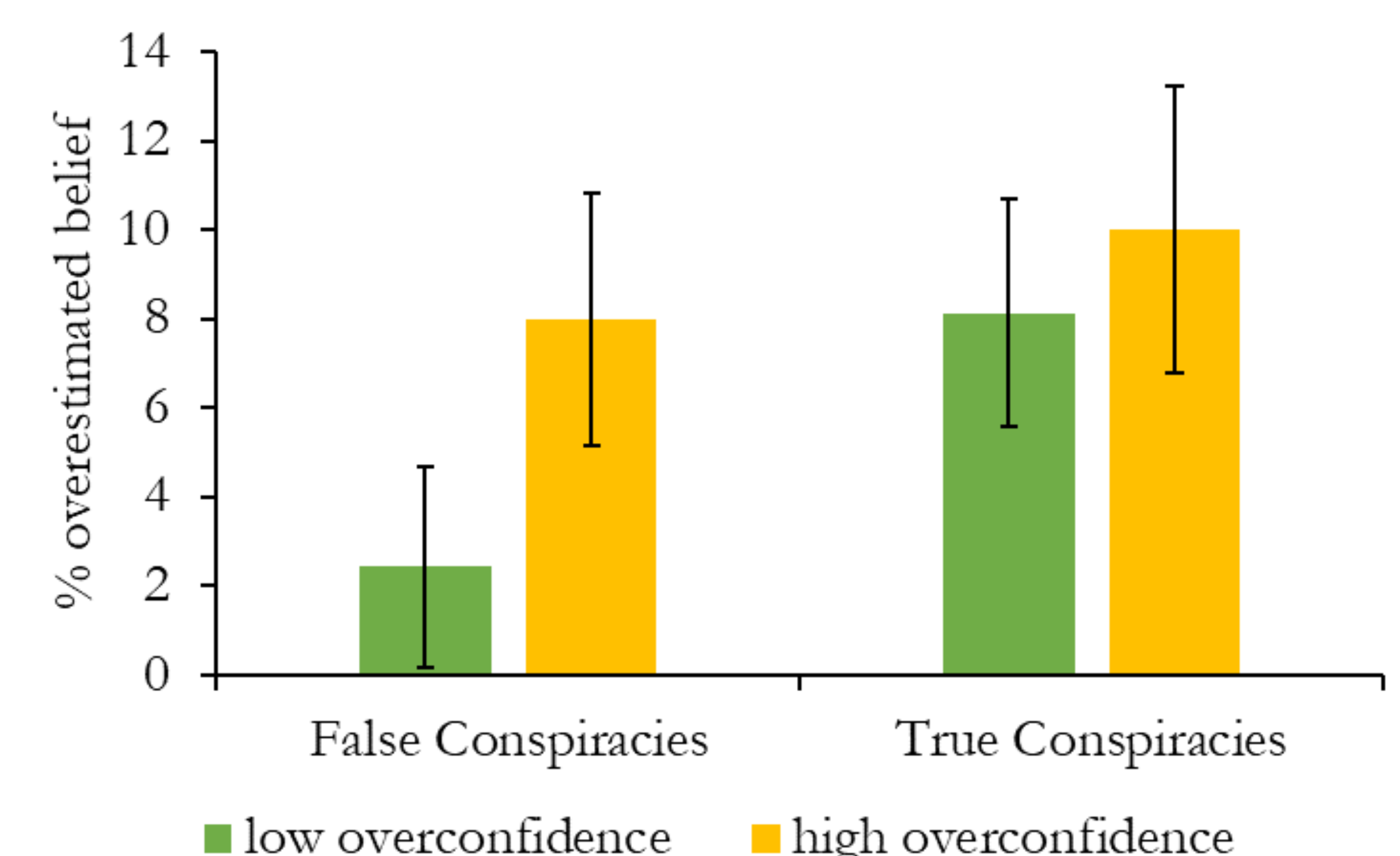
CRT Acc .11, -.11**, -.19***	Numeracy Acc .01, -.12**, -.22**	Perceptual Acc -.03, -.09*, -.08
Overconfidence -.06, .29***, .20***	Overconfidence .08, .34***, .30***	Overconfidence .06, .33***, .29***



Overestimated agreement

Correlation b/w overestimated agreement and accuracy/overconfidence (for Studies 1, 2, 3)

CRT Acc .11, -.11**, -.19***	Numeracy Acc .01, -.12**, -.22**	Perceptual Acc -.03, -.09*, -.08
Overconfidence -.06, .29***, .20***	Overconfidence .08, .34***, .30***	Overconfidence .06, .33***, .29***



Key Findings

- Conspiracy believers are both less analytic and overconfident as a disposition
- Conspiracy believers **massively overestimate** (>4X) how much others agree with them and this tendency was further associated with overconfidence